Let's not be undecided about Christian nationalism

Melissa K. Miller
Bowling Green State University
Nathan Englehart
Washington University in St. Louis

Let's not be undecided about Christian nationalism

- Prior measurement of Christian nationalism
- Methodology
- Findings
- Summary
- Future research

Prior measurement of Christian nationalism

- **Measured on Baylor Religion Survey**

  Wave II (2007), Wave V (2017), Wave VI (2021)

Prior measurement of Christian nationalism

- **Measured on Baylor Religion Survey**

  Wave II (2007), Wave V (2017), Wave VI (2021)

- **Used to predict political behavior and attitudes**

  Vote choice | Whitehead et al. 2018a
  Same-sex marriage | Perry & Whitehead 2015; Whitehead & Perry 2015
  Interracial marriage | Perry & Whitehead 2015; Whitehead & Perry 2015
  Gun control | Whitehead et al. 2018b
  Law enforcement | Perry et al. 2019
  Socialism, communism and globalism | Baker & Whitehead 2024
  Fear of immigrants, Muslims, white racial replacement | Baker & Whitehead 2024

Prior measurement of Christian nationalism

The federal government should…

…declare the United States a Christian nation

…advocate Christian values

…enforce strict separation of church and state*

…allow display of religious symbols in public places

…allow prayer in public schools

The success of the United States is part of God's plan

*Reverse coded.

Prior measurement of Christian nationalism

The federal governmer

...declare the Unitec

...advocate Christiar

...enforce strict sepa

...allow display of re

...allow prayer in pu

The success of the Uni

Strongly agree
Agree
Disagree
Strongly disagree
Undecided

Prior measurement of Christian nationalism

The federal governmer

...declare the Unitec

...advocate Christiar

...enforce strict sepa

...allow display of re

...allow prayer in pu

The success of the Uni

Aggregate measure treats undecided as midpoint

Strongly agree

Agree

Undecided

Disagree

Strongly disagree

Prior critiques

Dimensionality (Davis 2023; Li and Froese 2023)
Ambiguity / face validity (Smith and Adler, Jr. 2022)
Validity (Smith and Yancey 2025)

Prior critiques

Dimensionality (Davis 2023; Li and Froese 2023)

Ambiguity / face validity (Smith and Adler, Jr. 2022)

Validity (Smith and Yancey 2025)

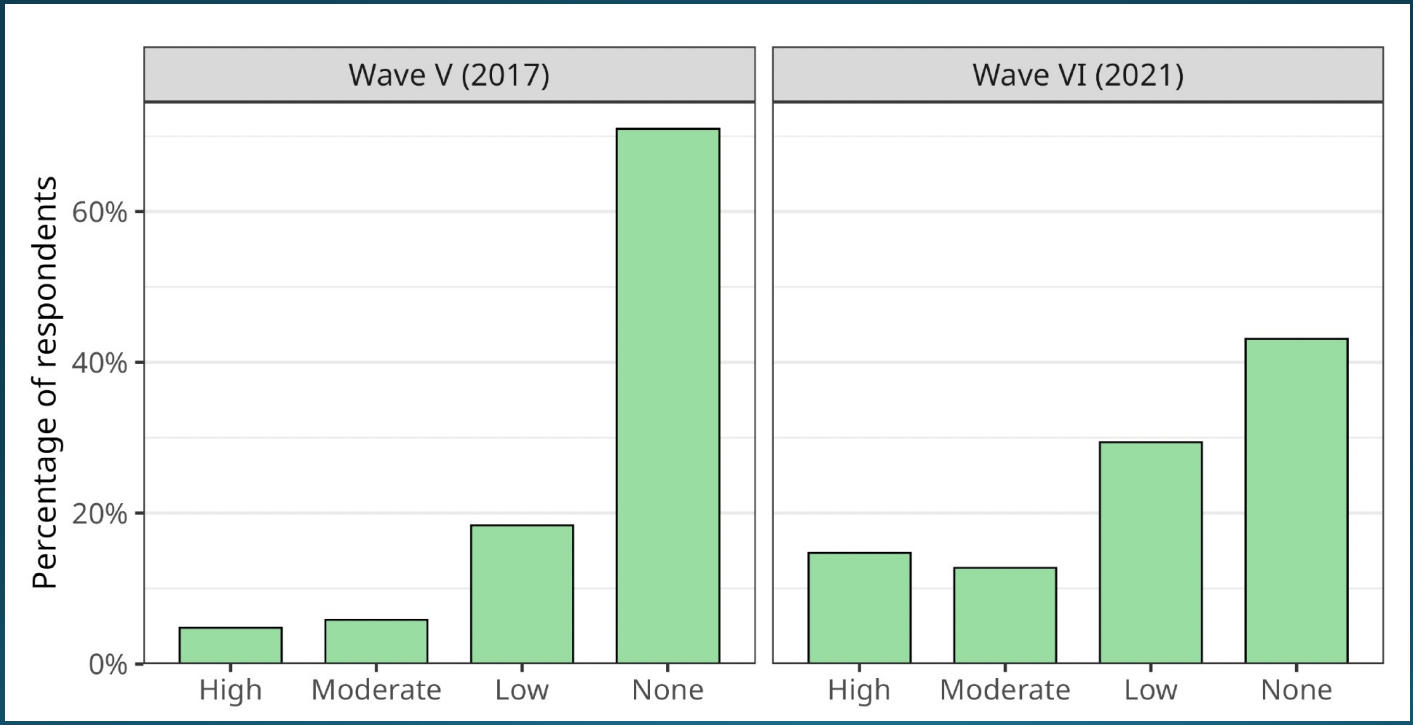
Treatment of undecided as midpoint

Do undecided responses reflect genuine uncertainty <u>or</u> satisficing (Krosnick 1991)?

Do undecided responses reflect genuine uncertainty <u>or</u> satisficing (Krosnick 1991)?

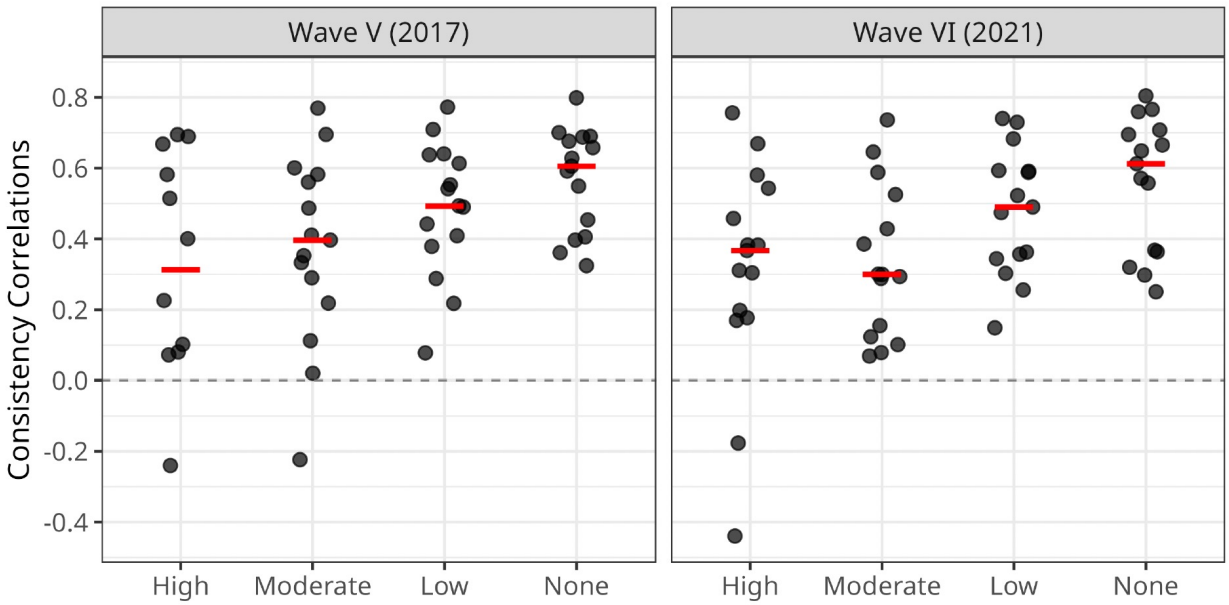
Wave V of Baylor Religion Survey (2017; n = 1,501)
Wave VI of Baylor Religion Survey (2021; n = 1,248)

Use of undecided option across 6 items



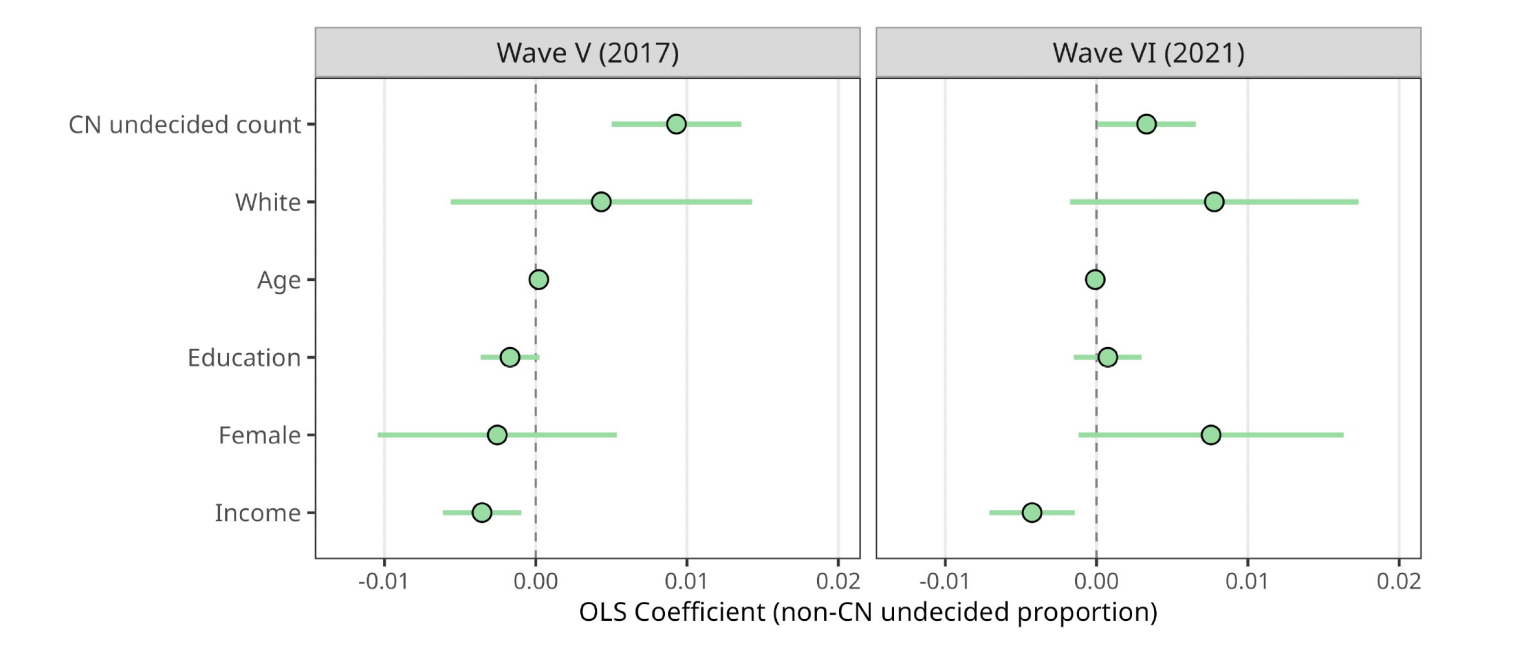
NOTE: High (3+ undecided); moderate (2 undecided); low (1 undecided); none (0 undecided)
SOURCE: Waves V and VI of Baylor Religion Survey

Undecided option and the consistency of Christian nationalism beliefs



NOTE: Each dot represents the Pearson r between one pair of CN scale items, computed within groups defined by the number of undecided responses across the six items. Red lines indicate group medians. Undecided responses excluded from correlation calculations. Two correlations below -0.4 omitted in both high conditions.
SOURCE: Waves V and VI of Baylor Religion Survey

Respondents who pick undecided on Christian nationalism tend to pick it on unrelated items



NOTE: Coefficients from OLS models predicting the number of undecided responses on unrelated questions with the number of undecided responses on Christian nationalism items. Error bars are 95 percent confidence intervals.
SOURCE: Waves V and VI of Baylor Religion Survey

Do undecided responses reflect genuine uncertainty <u>or</u> satisficing (Krosnick 1991)?

Evidence indicates satisficing

Should undecided be treated as midpoint, treated as missing, or omitted altogether?

Should undecided be treated as midpoint, treated as missing, or omitted altogether?

Bowling Green State University / YouGov Poll
October 2025 survey of Ohio registered voters
n = 1,048

Should undecided be treated as midpoint, treated as missing, or omitted altogether?

Bowling Green State University / YouGov Poll
October 2025 survey of Ohio registered voters
n = 1,048

Random half provided undecided option
Random half <u>not</u> provided undecided option

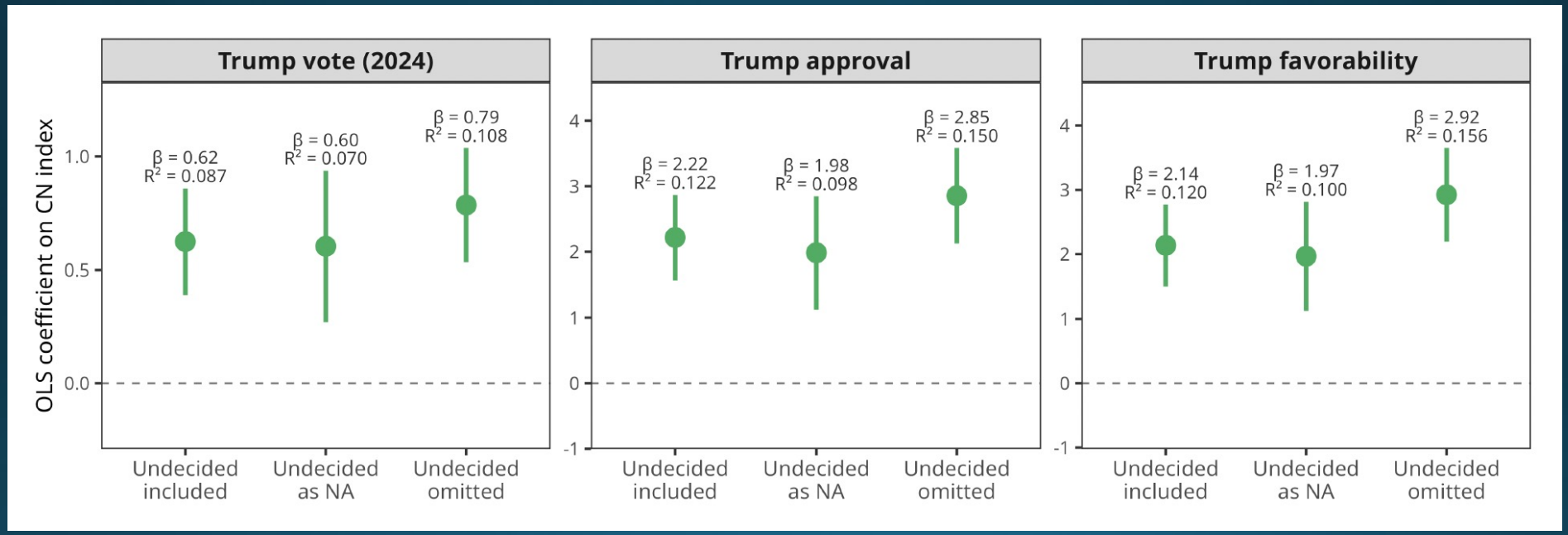
Should undecided be treated as midpoint, treated as missing, or omitted altogether?

Bowling Green State University / YouGov Poll
October 2025 survey of Ohio registered voters
n = 1,048

Undecided-included
Undecided-omitted
Undecided-as-missing

Undecided-omitted has highest predictive validity

Attitudes toward the Trump Administration

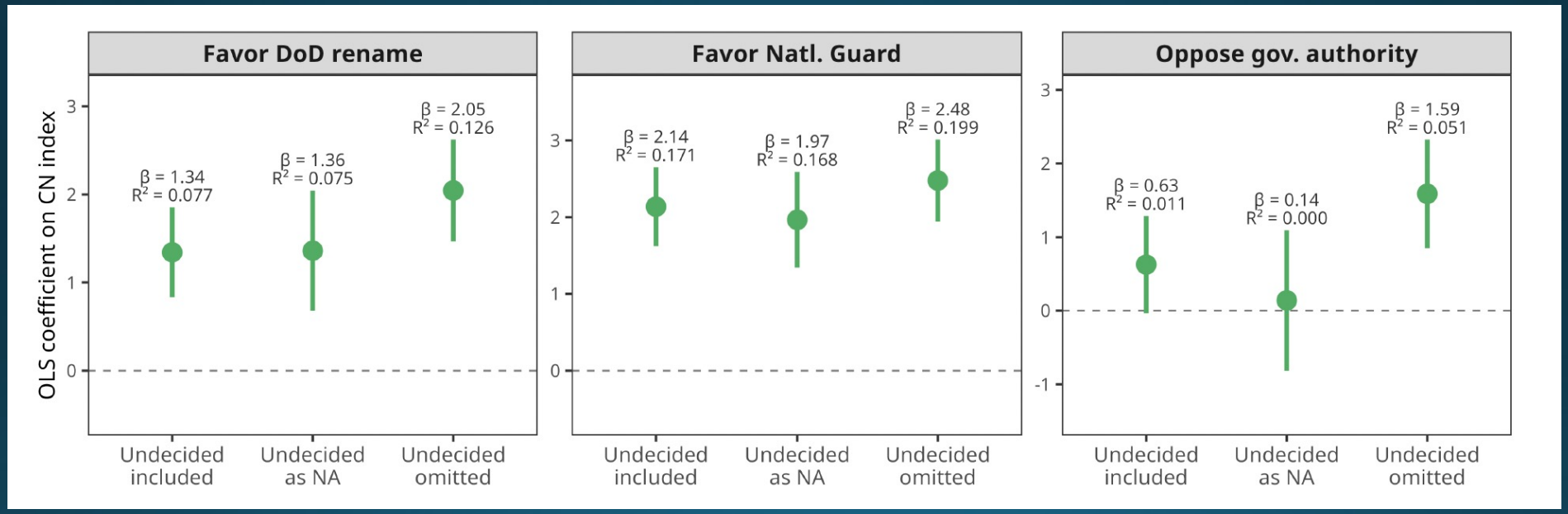


NOTE: Coefficients generated from separate OLS models with control variables; each presented with 95% confidence interval. Partial R^2 for each coefficient also reported.

SOURCE: October 2025 Bowling Green State University / YouGov Survey of Ohio registered voters.

Undecided-omitted has highest predictive validity

Attitudes toward Trump policies

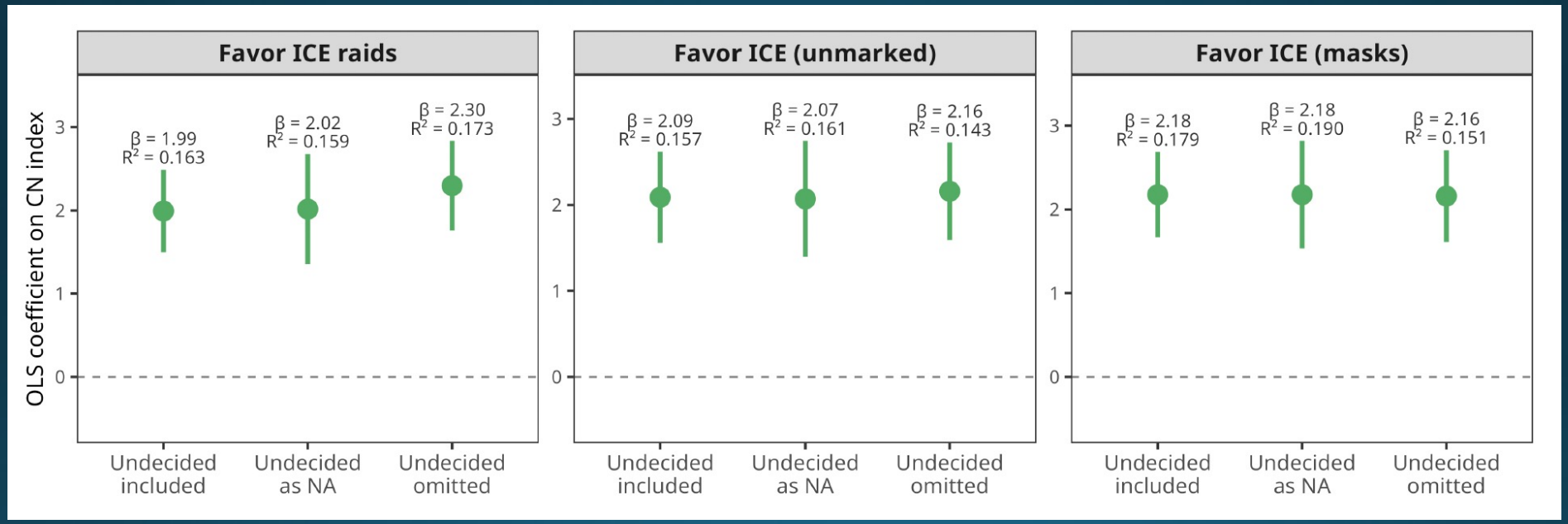


NOTE: Coefficients generated from separate OLS models with control variables; each presented with 95% confidence interval. Partial R^2 for each coefficient also reported.

SOURCE: October 2025 Bowling Green State University / YouGov Survey of Ohio registered voters.

Undecided-omitted has highest predictive validity

Attitudes toward ICE

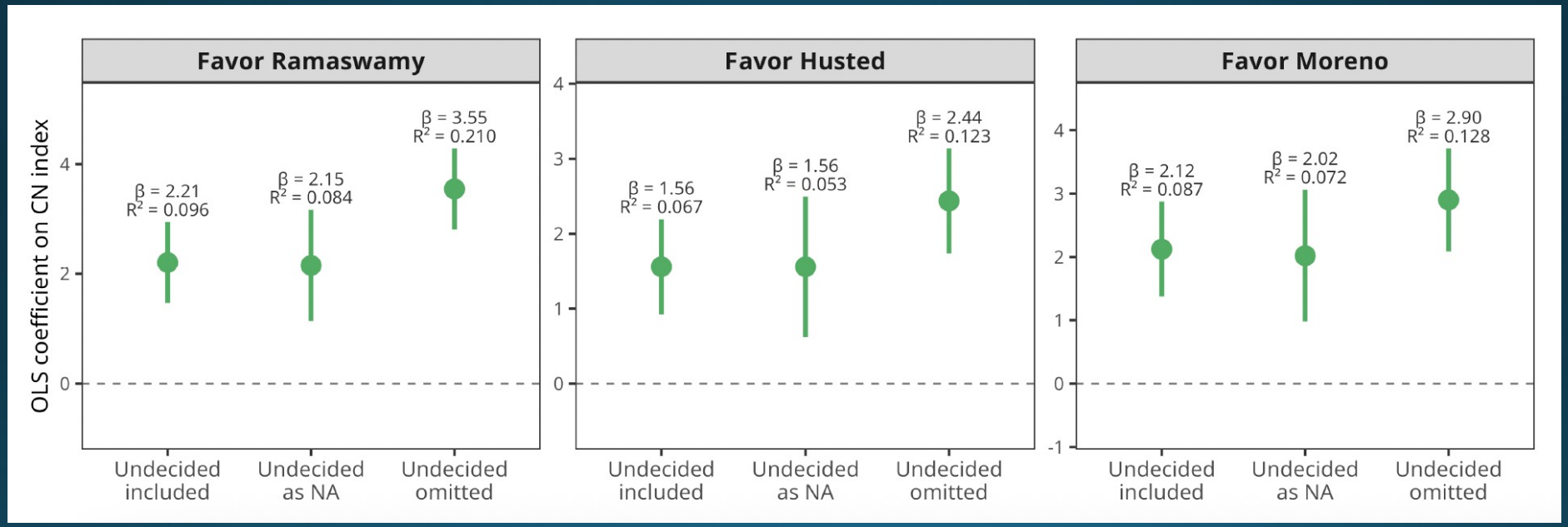


NOTE: Coefficients generated from separate OLS models with control variables; each presented with 95% confidence interval. Partial R^2 for each coefficient also reported.

SOURCE: October 2025 Bowling Green State University / YouGov Survey of Ohio registered voters.

Undecided-omitted has highest predictive validity

Attitudes toward prominent Ohio Republicans



NOTE: Coefficients generated from separate OLS models with control variables; each presented with 95% confidence interval. Partial R^2 for each coefficient also reported.

SOURCE: October 2025 Bowling Green State University / YouGov Survey of Ohio registered voters.

Summary

Popular Christian nationalism scale problematic

→ evidence of satisficing

→ treating undecided as midpoint compromises predictive validity

→ treating undecided as missing compromises predictive validity

Undecided-omitted alternative

→ reduces temptation to satisfice

→ improves predictive validity of the scale